

Consequential and Inherent Politics with Technology

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For starters Winner argues that the construction of technologies act similar to legislative acts as they both establish this framework for public order that lasts for many generations. Winner gives an example of this is the urban planning done by Robert Moses in New York. Moses intentionally designed many of the bridges such that the underpasses were too low for buses on the parkways. According to evidence provided by Moses' biographer, these designs were a reflection of Moses' racial prejudice as the automobile-owning white upper and middle classmen would be able to enjoy the park freely. However, poor people and blacks who predominately use public transport would not be able to use the park freely. Thus, this an excellent example of technologies having politics and being used as an instrument for political gain.

Winner theorized two different distinctions for technologies and their politics. The first of which are technologies that are consequentially political. These technologies are the ones where they were designed or invented with the concious effort to shape a political issue within a community. The bridges mentioned above are a perfect example of this as they were designed with the very intention to shape the lives of those who are a part of that community. However, I believe that urban planning and design falls into Winner's second category which is technologies with intrinsic politics.

According to Winner, technologies with intrinsic politics are the ones with much more power and are much more troubling to Winner. These technologies are ones that are bound to politics and Winner argues may even require such politics. Now why does urban planning fall into such a category? Well, urban planning requires the cooperation of a large amount of money, resources, and man power in order to come into fruition. As a result, urban planning is only really done by those who already have power and then the cityscape is planned to the whim of those with power. Another example would be search engines, which are optimized around creating data profiles for the individuals who use the search engine. This acts as a double edged sword for the user as the data profile (one may argue) brings better search results, but also allows their data to be sold off easier to advertisers. Additionally, the resources to run and manage such engines is enormous, further emphasizing the point that these sorts of technologies are left only for those with power.

Now besides the issues of technologies have politics, Galison points out another big issue with technology which are the issues of making things and also what things should we make. Foremost, Galison points out the issue that the line between artificial and natural are constantly blurring. Things like GMOs which appear natural but are modified, or the carbon fiber found in tennis rackets and airplane wings. Galison argues that the line between natural and artificial is blurring and that maybe such a distinction never worked well to begin with.

This then leads to Galison's problem of what should we make and what sort of boundaries should we not cross. The one that Galison focuses on in this section is human modifications

for things such as muscles, height, memory, etc. Galison writes about Michael Sandel's "case against perfection" which is grounded on the idea that who we are is a gift, something bestowed to us and is outside of our own bounds of modifications, rather than some sort of product where we as a society have meticulous control to shape the product. This argument is fundamentally different to the claim that humans shouldn't play god for safety reasons, rather that the modification of humans for perfection ultimately diminishes our humanity.

Works Cited

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